PIA3121 Theories of International Relations — Week 2 Summary: Root Discourses: Realism

1. Where Week 2 Sits in the Course

Keywords: root discourses, schedule, midterm quiz, Weeks 1–6, realism family

- Lecture of 8 Sep 2026, titled "Root Discourses: Realism" (Slide 1).
- Schedule to the midterm (Slide 2): 1 Sep Tools of Analysis / Foundational Concepts → **8 Sep Realism** → 15 Sep Liberalism → 22 Sep Neorealism and Neoliberalism → 29 Sep Economic Structuralism and Globalization → 6 Oct Constructivism → **13 Oct MIDTERM QUIZ**.
- After the midterm: six further topic weeks; **final quiz due 24 Nov**; **group paper due 8 Dec** (Slide 2).
- This week covers the whole realist family in one sweep: Classical Realism → Neorealism → Mastanduno 1999's update → Neoclassical Realism → Power Transition Theory.

2. Week 1 Recap: Tools Carried Forward

Keywords: security dilemma spiral, five sectors, sectoral analysis, partial reality

2.1 The Security Dilemma Spiral (Slide 3)

Keywords: mistrust, arming, misread intentions, self-fulfilling cycle

- Diagram recap: **A distrusts B → A arms → B reads A's arming as offensive → B arms → A's mistrust is "confirmed" → repeat** (Slide 3).
- Security dilemma: one state's defensive measures are perceived as threatening by another, which responds in kind, so both end up less secure.
- → Links to reification (Slide 25): belief in threat produces threat.

2.2 The Five Sectors and Their Trap (Slides 4–5)

Keywords: military, political, economic, socio-cultural, environmental, lens

- Five sectors as **lenses for analysis**: **Military, Political, Economic, Socio-Cultural, Environmental** (Slide 4) (memorise).
- **Danger in sectoral analysis:** the observer begins to confuse the partial reality of the sector with the total reality of the whole international system (Slide 5).
- → Realism is mainly a **military-political** lens; mistaking it for all of IR is this danger.

3. Discourse: Why Theories Are More Than Descriptions

Keywords: discourse, dominant discourse, cultural power, Foucault, root discourses, grooves of thought

3.1 Defining "Discourse" (Slides 6–8)

Keywords: what people write and say, culturally powerful, dominance

- Simple definition: discourse is what people are writing and saying about a phenomenon (Slide 7).
- Power step: the discourses of culturally powerful individuals and groups become dominant and start shaping the understandings of others (Slide 8).
- → Dominance depends on **who can circulate ideas**, not only truth.

3.2 Who Has Had the Power to Shape Discourse? (Slides 9–11)

Keywords: share of world GDP, GDP per capita, military spending, shifting power

- **"2,000 Years of Economic History in One Chart"** (share of world GDP) (Slide 9):
  - **China and India dominated** world output until ~1820.
  - **Western Europe, then the US**, rose after the Industrial Revolution; the **US share peaks mid-20th century**.
  - **China resurges after ~1980**.
- **GDP per capita 1900–2010** for France, Germany, USA, Russia/USSR, China (Slide 10): the **US is highest throughout**; **China very low until a rapid rise after ~1980**.
- **US military spending since 1950** (Al Jazeera chart) (Slide 11): the US spent **$778bn in 2020, more than the next 10 countries combined**.
- → Link to Slide 8: US economic and military weight let its IR discourse become the 20th-century default; China's return raises whose discourse dominates next.

3.3 Soft Power: The Ability to Coax and Persuade (Slide 12)

Keywords: soft power, universities, sports, arts and entertainment, The Economist

- Soft power: the ability to coax and persuade rather than coerce (Slide 12, citing *The Economist*, "Softly does it", 2015).
- Three critical factors (memorise):
  - **Universities**
  - **Sports**
  - **Arts and Entertainment**
- *Example:* dominant universities export theories, textbooks and graduates, spreading their IR discourse.

3.4 Foucault: Discourse Produces Reality (Slides 13–17, 77)

Keywords: Foucault, Archaeology of Knowledge, what can be said, what can be thought, root discourse, self-evident truths

- "Then it gets deeper" (Slide 13): Foucault, *The Archaeology of Knowledge* and *The Discourse on Language* (Slide 14).
- Foucault's claim: discourses produce what we come to see as real, and therefore what becomes real (Slide 15).
- They determine what **can** (not just "may") be said, and **even what can be thought** (Slide 15).
    - "May" = permission; "can" = the limits of what is even thinkable inside the discourse.
- **Root discourses** (Slides 16–17): IR theories such as Realism and Liberalism can be treated as root discourses: theories that established deep-seated, historically rooted grooves of thought.
    - These grooves **channeled and conditioned later thinking** once, through **repetition**, they became "obvious," "natural," self-evident truths (Slide 17).
- One-liner: *a root discourse wins not only by being right but by being repeated until it looks like common sense.*

4. What Is "Root" About Realism?

Keywords: oldest school, Thucydides, Peloponnesian War, American dominance, idealists, Tribute System, reification

4.1 Thucydides: The First Known Realist (Slides 18–20, 33)

Keywords: Thucydides, Peloponnesian War, Melian Dialogue, Athens, Sparta, fear of rising power

- Realism is **the oldest "school" of thought in IR** (Slide 18).
- Thucydides (c. 460–395 BCE): the **first known Realist**, though similar thinkers appeared soon after **in China and elsewhere** (Slide 19).
- He analysed the **Peloponnesian War (431–404 BCE)** between Athens and Sparta.
- Two key quotes (memorise):
    - **"The strong do what they can, and the weak suffer what they must."** (Slides 19, 33): power, not justice, decides outcomes.
    - **"The growth in the power of Athens, and the alarm which this inspired in [Sparta], made war inevitable."** (Slide 20): a rising power plus a fearful established power equals war. This is the ancient root of Power Transition Theory (Section 9).
- Discussion question (Slide 20): **was Athens' acquisition of power purely for defensive reasons?**
    - → If not, it is not a pure security dilemma: the riser may also be ambitious.

4.2 Realism's Rise to Dominance (Slides 21–24)

Keywords: 1939, Cold War, international lawyers, idealists, China-centred Tribute System, American IR

- Realism **dominated IR in America from 1939 until the 1980s**, and **shared the dominant position from the 1980s to today** (not always in the 1990s) (Slide 21).
- It did **not** always dominate globally before 1939 (Slide 22):
    - **Western Europe:** international lawyers increasingly influential from the 1600s.
    - **1920s–30s:** "Idealists" dominant.
    - **East Asia:** the **China-centred Tribute System** flourished.
- After 1939 and through the Cold War, realism became dominant in **America, the Soviet Union and China**, and **American IR theory became the most influential globally** (Slide 23).
- Key question (Slide 24): was realism dominant because it was **empirically RIGHT**, or because the **powerful states were promoting and practising** it?

4.3 Reification (Slide 25)

Keywords: reification, anarchy, belief, self-fulfilling prophecy

- Reification: treating an idea or belief as if it were a concrete, objective thing.
- Slide 25's question: **which comes first, anarchy, or the belief that anarchy is a real threat that states must counter (thereby creating anarchy)?**
- One-liner: *realism may describe the world partly because states that believe it act it out.*

5. Classical Realism: Morgenthau's Six Principles

Keywords: Morgenthau, Politics Among Nations, interest defined as power, prudence, national interest, autonomy of politics

5.1 Hans J. Morgenthau (Slides 26, 38)

Keywords: Morgenthau, Politics Among Nations, struggle for power and peace

- Hans J. Morgenthau (1904–1980), author of *Politics Among Nations: The Struggle for Power and Peace* (Slides 26, 38), the founding text of post-1939 American Classical Realism.
- His **Six Principles of Political Realism** are the core list for the quiz (memorise all six).

5.2 Principle 1: Objective Laws (Slides 27–28)

Keywords: laws of politics, reasoned analysis, identity does not matter

- International politics is **governed by laws** that can be **uncovered through reasoned analysis** (Slide 27).

- The **consciousness, identity or culture** of the people who run states **doesn't matter much** (Slide 28).

5.3 Principle 2: Interest Defined as Power (Slides 29–31)

Keywords: interest defined as power, prudence, rational decision-making, outliers

- Statesmen **think and act in terms of interest defined as power** (Slide 29).
- This tends to **induce PRUDENCE** in foreign and security policy, based on **careful and rational decision-making** (Slide 30).
- **"What about Trump?"** (Slide 31): a **normal distribution** (bell curve):
    - 68.26% of cases within ±1 SD; 95.44% within ±2 SD; 99.72% within ±3 SD.
    - Point: **Trump as an outlier / tail case**. Theories built on typical, prudent behaviour may fail on leaders far from the mean.

5.4 Principle 3: Universal Validity (Slides 32–33)

Keywords: universal, all times and places, Thucydides as evidence

- The principle that statesmen act in terms of interest defined as power is **universally valid, in all times and places** (Slide 32).
- *Example:* Thucydides' "the strong do what they can…" (Slide 33): the same logic in 5th-century BCE Greece as in the 20th century.

5.5 Principle 4: States Have Their Own Morality (Slides 34–35)

Keywords: no universal moral law, state morality, national interest as moral duty

- **Universal moral laws or globe-wide cultural values cannot be used to judge a state's behaviour**; **states have their own morality** (Slide 34).
- **EXCEPT:** a state has **no right to sacrifice "its" nation** for some grand moral vision. **All states have a moral duty to defend or advance the "national interest"** (Slide 35).
- → Realism is not amoral: its morality is **prudence and the national interest**.

5.6 Principle 5: No Moral Crusades (Slide 36)

Keywords: do not universalise, no preaching, moral presumption

- States **must not try to universalise their particular moral vision**; they must not be **preachy and morally presumptuous** (Slide 36).

5.7 Principle 6: The Autonomy of Politics (Slide 37)

Keywords: distinct political sphere, not an economy, not a society, not a network

- **Politics and IR are distinct from other social spheres** and must be analysed as such (Slide 37).
- You **can't assume** the international political realm works like **an economy, a society, a network**, etc. (Slide 37).

- → Contrast Waltz's market analogy (Slide 45).

6. Neorealism (Structural Realism)

Keywords: Waltz, Theory of International Politics, scientific rigour, structure, anarchy, black box, polarity

6.1 Origins: IR Imitates Economics (Slides 39–40)

Keywords: economics as model science, US political science, 1970s, Waltz 1979

- Because of its **scientific rigour, conceptual clarity, elegant explanations and predictive success**, **economics** became the model social science for many US IR scholars in the **1950s–60s** (Slide 39).
- This was **not** the case in **Europe (incl. Britain), Australia** and elsewhere (Slide 39).
- Neorealism was **born in the 1970s**: Waltz 1979, *Theory of International Politics* (Slide 40).

6.2 The Neorealists' Two Main Objectives (Slides 41–43)

Keywords: scientific realism, transnational relations, interdependence, neoliberal challenge

1. **Make Classical Realism more scientific and rigorous**: move it away from history, philosophy and law toward **economics and the natural sciences**, while **still adhering to Morgenthau's Six Principles** (Slide 41).
2. **Put down a theoretical challenge** from scholars of **transnational relations and interdependence** ("neoliberals" in the IR sense) (Slide 42).

- Why that challenge mattered: **world exports as % of GDP rose from ~12% (1960) to ~30% (2014)** (Slide 43).

6.3 The System as a Market (Slides 45–46)

Keywords: market analogy, supply and demand, equilibrium, structure

- To Waltz, **the international system was very much like a market** (Slide 45): a supply/demand graphic, with **equilibrium set by the structure, not by any single firm**.
- States are like firms: each jostles for advantage, but the **outcome of competitive state jostling is international STRUCTURE** (Slide 46).
- Structure: the principles by which units are arranged into an international system, how units are differentiated from each other, and how they stand in relation to each other in terms of relative capabilities (Slide 46) (memorise).

6.4 The Three Dimensions of International Structure (Slides 47–50)

Keywords: ordering principle, hierarchy vs anarchy, functional differentiation, like units, distribution of capabilities

3. **Ordering Principle** (Slide 48): **binary, either hierarchy or anarchy**.
    - Anarchy: the absence of any authority above states, not chaos (standard sense).
4. **Functional Differentiation of Units** (Slide 49): because the system is anarchic and **survival is paramount**, all states must perform the **same basic tasks**. They are **functionally similar**, whether democracies or dictatorships.
    - Black box: Waltz treats the insides of states as black boxes, ignoring regime type and domestic politics.
5. **Distribution of Capabilities** (Slide 50): **this is where systems differ**. Is power concentrated in **one** state, **two** (**bipolarity**, like the Cold War) or **many** (**multipolarity**)? This distribution **dictates the nature of international competition**.

- → Under anarchy, dimensions 1 and 2 are constant, so **only polarity varies**.
- One-liner: *anarchy + like units + distribution of power = structure; change the distribution, change the system.*

6.5 Why Bipolarity Is More Stable than Multipolarity (Slides 51–55)

Keywords: conflict dyads, deterrence, miscalculation, buck-passing, chain-ganging

6. **Simple math** (Slide 52): **five great powers = ten potential conflict pairings; bipolar = one**. Fewer chances for great-power war.
    - n(n−1)/2: 5 × 4 / 2 = 10.
7. **Easier deterrence, less miscalculation** (Slide 53): threats are **clearer** and the adversary **unambiguous**. The two superpowers watch each other's every move → more careful calculation, fewer catastrophic misjudgments of **capabilities or resolve**.
8. **Less "Buck-Passing" and "Chain-Ganging"** (Slides 54–55):
    - Buck-passing: facing a rising threat, states in a multipolar system hope another great power will bear the cost of confronting it. **Risk:** the aggressor grows too powerful (Slide 54).
    - Chain-ganging: states see their security as so intertwined with their allies' that they get dragged into peripheral conflicts (Slide 55).
    - *Example:* the **alliance system before WWI** (Slide 55).

6.6 Illustrations: WWI Multipolarity vs Cold War Bipolarity (Slides 44, 56–57)

Keywords: 1914 alliances, Triple Alliance, Triple Entente, Cold War map, proxy insurgencies

- **"Chain-Ganging Under Multipolarity Leads to World War I"** (Slide 56): 1914 alliance map.

    - **Triple Alliance:** Germany, Austria-Hungary, Italy.
    - **Triple Entente:** France, Russia, UK, plus Russia's Slavic allies **Serbia and Montenegro**.

- **"Stable Cold War Bipolarity, 1980"** (Slides 44, 57): world map.

    - **Red x's:** communist insurgencies against US-supporting states.
    - **Blue x's:** right-wing insurgencies against USSR-supporting states.
    - → "Stable" means **no direct great-power war**. Conflict moved to the periphery as **proxy insurgencies**.

6.7 Anarchy as the System-Level Driver (Slides 58, 73)

Keywords: levels of analysis, system level, anarchy

- **Levels-of-analysis diagram** with **"ANARCHY!"** at the **system level** (Slides 58, 73).
- Neorealism explains at the **system level**; leaders and domestic politics are bracketed out. Neoclassical realism brings them back (Section 8).

7. Mastanduno's Update: Four Fundamental Realist Assumptions

Keywords: Mastanduno 1999, Unipolar Politics, territorial actors, rationality, power-seeking, relative position

- Mastanduno 1999 sought to **update neorealism itself**; book: *Unipolar Politics: Realism and State Strategies After the Cold War* (Slide 59).
- Context: the Cold War's end left a **unipolar** world, which bipolar-focused neorealism had not anticipated.
- **Four fundamental realist assumptions** (Slides 60–63) (memorise):

9. The most important actors in world politics are **territorially organised entities** (Slide 60).
10. State behaviour can be explained as the product of **rational decision-making** (Slide 61).
11. **All states seek power, but they don't all necessarily seek to maximise power** (Slide 62).
12. Relations among states are **inherently competitive** as states strive to **improve their relative positions** (Slide 63).

- → Assumption 3 softens neorealism; assumption 4 means gains are judged **relative to rivals**.

8. Neoclassical Realism (NCR)

Keywords: neoclassical realism, independent variable, intervening variables, dependent variable, leader perceptions, state-society relations

8.1 The Core Model (Slides 64–68)

Keywords: systemic pressure, domestic filter, foreign policy outcome

- Neoclassical Realism: a **new school of thought from the 1990s–2010s** (Slide 64).
- Neoclassical realism agrees that the systemic distribution of power is the primary driver of foreign policy, but holds that systemic pressures are filtered through domestic-level intervening variables (Slide 65).
- Causal chain (memorise):

13. **Systemic pressures (independent variable)** (Slide 66): **anarchy, distribution of capabilities** (e.g., the rise of a rival power).
14. **Intervening variables (domestic factors)** (Slide 67):

    - **a. Leader perceptions:** how do leaders understand external threats and opportunities? Are they **risk-averse or risk-acceptant**?
    - **b. State-society relations:** how easily can leaders **mobilise societal resources** for foreign-policy goals? (e.g., **tax revenue, military conscription**).
    - **c. Domestic institutions: democratic checks and balances, powerful bureaucracies**, etc.

15. **Foreign policy outcome (dependent variable)** (Slide 68): **the specific diplomatic, military or economic strategy** a state pursues.

- *Example:* two states facing the same rising rival respond differently if one has a risk-acceptant leader and easy conscription, the other strong legislative checks.
- One-liner: *system proposes, domestic politics disposes.*

8.2 Critiques of Neoclassical Realism (Slides 69–72)

Keywords: loss of parsimony, kitchen sink, unfalsifiable, permissive environment, is it still IR theory

16. **Loss of parsimony** (Slide 70):

    - Waltz's neorealism was "beautiful" because it explained big outcomes with **a single variable**: the distribution of power under anarchy.
    - NCR adds **messy domestic factors**: leader psychology, bureaucratic politics, legislative-executive relations, national culture.
    - Critics: a "kitchen sink" theory: one into which you can throw any variable you want to explain a case.

17. **Not falsifiable** (Slide 71), **"the biggest challenge"**:

    - If a state **balances** against a rising power as neorealism predicts → "systemic pressures were transmitted."

- If it **fails to balance** → "flawed domestic institutions or misperceptions blocked transmission."
- Unfalsifiable: a theory that can explain both an outcome and its opposite risks explaining nothing at all.

18. **Downgrading the international system** (Slide 72):

- If domestic variables do the heavy lifting, the system looks less like a **determinant structure** and more like a **permissive environment** or background condition.
- Critics ask: in what meaningful way is this **still a realist or systemic theory**, or even **an IR theory**, if the international level no longer matters much?

9. Power Transition Theory

Keywords: power transition, hegemon, challenger, parity, dissatisfaction, US–China

9.1 The Hegemon–Challenger Curve (Slide 74)

Keywords: hegemon (US), challenger (China?), crossover, danger zone

- Diagram (Slide 74): a **Hegemon (US)** power line and a rising **Challenger (China?)** line **converging**; the **crossover point is the danger zone**.
- Power Transition Theory (associated with Organski 1958): war is most likely when a rising challenger approaches parity with the dominant power.
- *Example:* the US–China relationship, with China's post-1980 economic resurgence (Slides 9–10) as the rising line.

9.2 Parity and Satisfaction Decide Severity (Slide 75)

Keywords: relative power, satisfaction, severity of conflict, peace, integration

- 3-D surface (Slide 75): **severity of conflict** plotted against:
  - **Relative power:** defender preponderant → **parity** → challenger preponderant.
  - **Satisfaction:** dissatisfied vs satisfied challenger.
- Findings (memorise):
  - Conflict is **most severe at PARITY with a DISSATISFIED challenger**.
  - **Satisfied parity → peace, stable alliance, integration**.
- Plotted examples: **Kashmir, Israel–Palestine, Afghanistan & Chechnya** (Slide 75).
- → Power shifts alone don't cause war; **parity plus dissatisfaction** does. The China question is whether it is **satisfied** with the US-led order.
- One-liner: *parity + dissatisfaction = danger; parity + satisfaction = partnership.*

10. Through the Realist Lens, and the Discourse Warning

Keywords: Mearsheimer, Conversations with History, realist lens, Foucault revisited

- **"Through the Realist Lens"** (Slide 76): Kreisler 2002, Harry Kreisler's *Conversations with History* interview with John Mearsheimer, a leading contemporary realist.
- → Realism is both an **analytical lens** and a **root discourse**: is its dominance proof it is **right**, or of **power** (Slide 24)?

11. Reading Link: Viotti & Kauppi, "Realism: The State and Balance of Power"

Keywords: state-centric, unitary actor, rational actor, national security, balance of power

- The reading's standard summary of realist assumptions lines up with Morgenthau and Mastanduno:
    - **States are the principal actors** (Mastanduno 1: territorial entities).
    - **The state is a unitary actor** (Waltz's black box).
    - **The state is a rational actor** (Morgenthau 2; Mastanduno 2).
    - **National security tops the agenda**, with military-political issues as "high politics" (sectoral lens, Slide 4).
- Balance of Power: the tendency of states under anarchy to counter a dominant or rising power, by building their own strength or forming alliances, so that no single state dominates.
    - Links: balancing is what the NCR falsifiability critique tests (Slide 71); buck-passing and chain-ganging are balancing failures (Slides 54–55).

12. One-Page Revision Spine

Keywords: last-minute recap, realist family, discourse, structure, quiz

19. **Week 1 tools:** security dilemma spiral; five sectors (military, political, economic, socio-cultural, environmental); don't mistake a sector for the whole system (Slides 3–5).
20. **Discourse** = what people write and say; the culturally powerful make theirs dominant, backed by GDP, military spending ($778bn in 2020) and soft power (universities, sports, arts) (Slides 7–12).
21. **Foucault:** discourses produce what becomes real and what *can* be thought; Realism and Liberalism are **root discourses** made "natural" by repetition (Slides 14–17, 77).
22. **Thucydides:** "the strong do what they can…"; Athens' rise plus Sparta's alarm made war inevitable (Slides 19–20, 33).
23. **Dominance:** US IR from 1939, shared since the 1980s; earlier rivals were international lawyers, idealists, the Tribute System. Right, or promoted by the powerful? Reification: belief in anarchy creates anarchy (Slides 21–25).
24. **Hans J. Morgenthau's Six:** objective laws; interest defined as power → prudence (Trump as outlier); universal; states' own morality, national interest as duty; no moral crusades; politics autonomous (Slides 26–38).

25. **Waltz 1979:** realism made scientific (economics model) and defended against interdependence; system as market; structure = ordering principle + like units (black box) + distribution of capabilities (Slides 39–50, 58).
26. **Bipolarity more stable:** 1 dyad vs 10; clearer deterrence; less buck-passing and chain-ganging; WWI alliances vs Cold War proxy wars (Slides 44, 51–57).
27. **Mastanduno 1999:** territorial actors; rational; seek but don't all maximise power; competition over relative position (Slides 59–63).
28. **NCR:** systemic pressure (IV) → leader perceptions, state-society relations, domestic institutions → foreign policy (DV); critiques: lost parsimony, unfalsifiable, system downgraded (Slides 64–73).
29. **Power transition:** hegemon (US) vs challenger (China?); worst conflict at **parity with a dissatisfied challenger** (Slides 74–75).
30. **Closing:** Mearsheimer's realist lens; Foucault again. Realism is both a lens and a root discourse (Slides 76–77).